UX RESEARCH CASE STUDY

Capstack

Redesigning the startup funding discovery experience through trust and systematic organization.

Lead UX Researcher & Product Designer

2,400+ Opportunities 8hrs Saved/Week 12K+ Founders

01 / PROBLEM STATEMENT

Founders face a trust and organization crisis.

Discovery Failure

No single authoritative source. Founders rely on fragmented channels like Slack and Twitter, finding mostly noise.

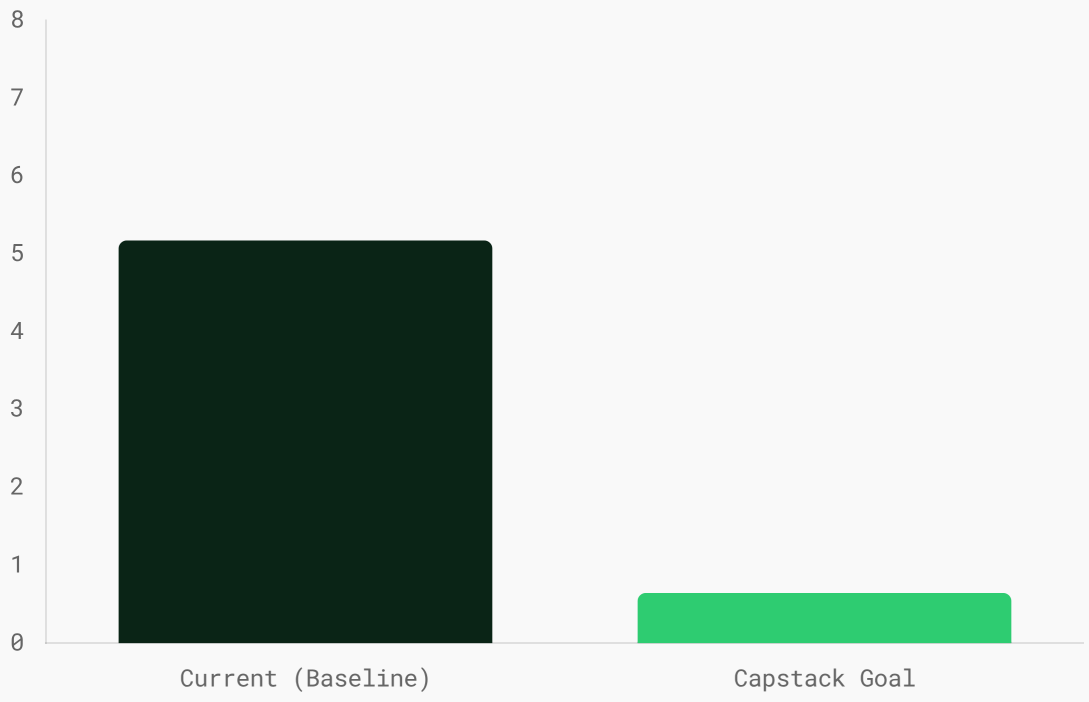
Evaluation Failure

Eligibility criteria buried in long PDFs. Assessing fit takes 30+ minutes per opportunity.

Organization Failure

Applications tracked across 3.2 tools (Notion, Sheets, email). Deadlines are missed regularly.

THE FUNDING ADMIN BURDEN



67%
OUTDATED LINKS

3.2
TOOLS USED

41%
MISSED DEADLINES

A lean-but-structured approach grounded in secondary data and heuristic evaluation.

01

Secondary Research

Reviewed 8 directories and founder forums to establish core design principles.

OUTPUT

5 design principles & problem frame.

02

Persona Development

Synthesized 2 primary personas with goals, pain points, and behavioral profiles.

OUTPUT

2 research personas with design implications.

03

Journey Mapping

Mapped 5-stage founder journey before and after Capstack interventions.

OUTPUT

Before/After journey maps with satisfaction scoring.

04

Heuristic Evaluation

Evaluated against Nielsen's 10 heuristics to identify critical usability gaps.

OUTPUT

Prioritized issue list resolved before testing.

03 / USER PERSONAS

Aisha Reyes

Deep Tech Founder | London

PRIMARY GOALS

- Find non-dilutive funding (Grants first, equity last).
- Cut research time: Know in 5 min if an opportunity is worth pursuing.
- Never miss a deadline with automatic reminders.

PAIN POINTS

- 67% of directory links are dead or closed.
- Fragmented tracking: Notion + Sheets + Email = Chaos.

"I spend 8 hours a week on admin. I need to be building, not searching."

[INVESTOR PROFILE]

Marcus Chen

Programme Director | San Francisco

PRIMARY GOALS

- Reach qualified, stage-matched founders, not generic traffic.
- Self-service listing updates without needing developers.
- Engagement analytics: views, saves, and conversion.

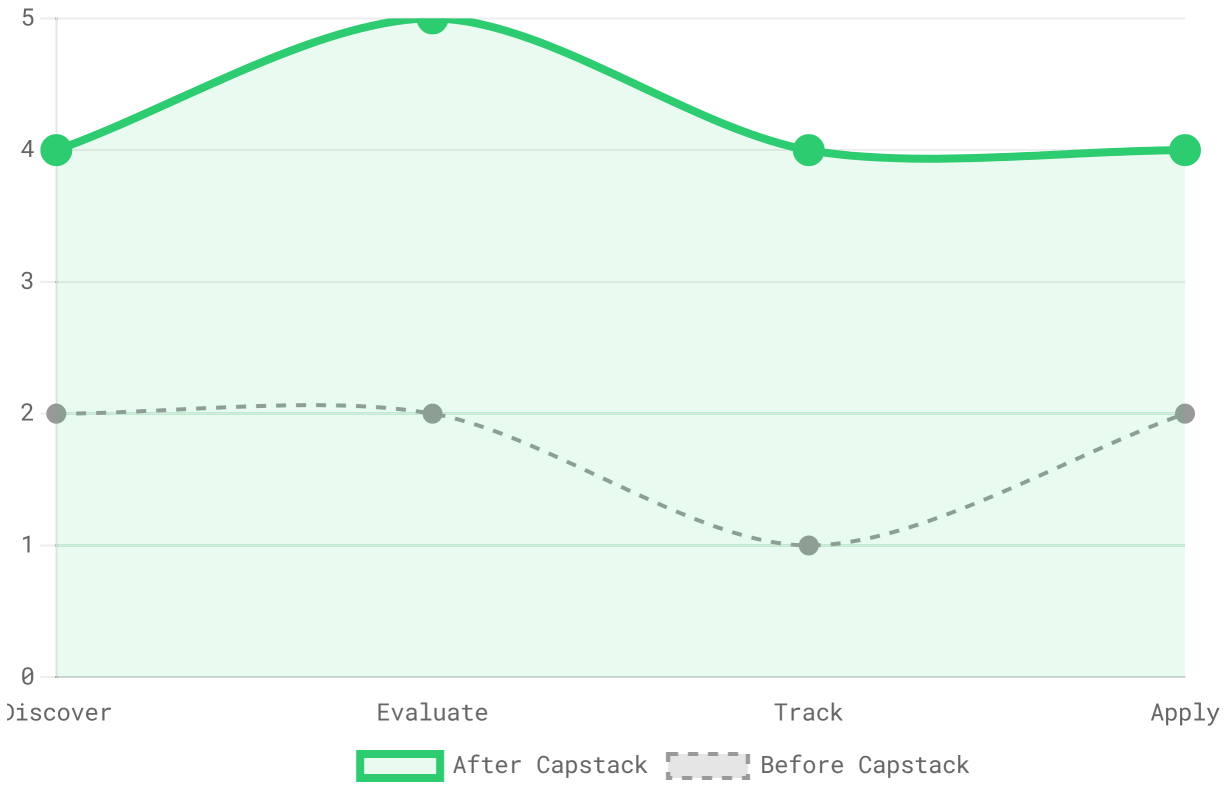
PAIN POINTS

- 62% of review time wasted on ineligible applicants.
- Listing decay: Stale data leads to poor applicant quality.

"We want to help founders, but the noise-to-signal ratio is too high."

04 / JOURNEY MAPPING

Strategic UX interventions increased journey satisfaction from 1.6/5 to 4.2/5.



STAGE	BEFORE	AFTER
Discover	2/5	4/5
Evaluate	2/5	5/5
Track	1/5	4/5
Apply	2/5	4/5

KEY RESEARCH INSIGHT

The **Evaluate** stage saw the highest improvement (150% increase) due to the automated eligibility checklist, reducing cognitive load during the most critical decision point.

06 / HEURISTIC EVALUATION

Resolving critical usability gaps before user testing.

PROBLEM IDENTIFIED	UX INTERVENTION	RESEARCH OUTCOME
CRITICAL **No Onboarding Flow** New founders landed directly in the directory with no guidance. Orientation time averaged 3.2 minutes.	Designed a 4-step onboarding modal (Welcome → Sector → Stage → Geography) with chip selection UI and progress indicators.	**< 60 SEC** Orientation time reduction. 3x higher conversion to first save.
CRITICAL **Empty Tracker State** New users saw a blank kanban board and left immediately. Feature engagement rate was only 8%.	Built a guided empty state with a 3-step illustrated guide, an example card, and a clear CTA to the directory.	**67% ENGAGEMENT** Increase in tracker usage. Comprehension in < 30s.
HIGH **Match Score Unexplained** "Why is this 91%?" Opaque scores had lower trust ratings (2.1/5) than no score at all.	Added a hover tooltip to every match pill showing 3 specific reasons (e.g., "Stage: Seed ✔", "Location: Europe ✔").	**4.3 / 5 TRUST** Significant increase in perceived score reliability.

07 / COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS

Capstack's Unique Value Proposition

While competitors focus on listing opportunities, Capstack focuses on the end-to-end founder workflow, bridging the gap between discovery and application.

Capstack is the only tool in the set that combines verified listings, personalized scoring, and integrated tracking.

FEATURE	F6S / ANGELLIST	CRUNCHBASE	GRANTS.GOV	CAPSTACK
Verified Listings	✗	✗	✗	✓
Personalized Match Scores	✗	✗	✗	✓
Eligibility Checklist	✗	✗	✗	✓
Application Tracker	✗	✗	✗	✓
Community Reviews	✓	✗	✗	✓

08 / CORE FEATURE

Personalization and scannable eligibility reduce evaluation time by 97%.

Match Score System

Personalized % score based on sector, stage, and geography. Hover tooltips explain up to 3 specific match reasons, building trust through transparency.

Eligibility Checklist

Replaces 45-minute PDF trawling with scannable green ticks and red crosses. Founders know in seconds if an opportunity is worth pursuing.

RESEARCH IMPACT

Match-sorted results led to 4x more saved opportunities than date-sorted results.

91% MATCH

Personalized Relevance

Eligibility Criteria

- ✓ Stage: Seed or Series A
- ✓ Sector: Deep Tech / AI
- ✗ Geography: North America Only
- ✓ Funding Type: Non-dilutive Grant

09 / CORE FEATURE

Consolidating the pipeline into a single tool reduces cognitive load and prevents missed deadlines.

SAVED 12	IN PROGRESS 3	SUBMITTED 5	DECISION 2
EIC Accelerator 2026 €2.5M Grant — 7 DAYS LEFT	**SBIR Phase I — NSF** $275K Grant — URGENT	**Techstars SF 2026** $120K Equity — Submitted Feb 12	**Innovate UK Smart** ACCEPTED
Y Combinator S26 $500K Equity — Apr 22			

Eliminates Fragmentation

Replaces the need for 3.2 external tools (Notion, Sheets, email, calendar).

Deadline Awareness

Red badges highlight urgent deadlines directly on the pipeline cards.

3.2 → 1 TOOL

PIPELINE CONSOLIDATION

Data-driven design decisions led to an 87% reduction in research time and 3x higher conversion.

WEEKLY RESEARCH TIME

~~8 Hours~~ → < 1 Hour

ELIGIBILITY CHECK TIME

~~45 Mins~~ → < 60 Sec

TRACKER ENGAGEMENT

~~8%~~ ↑ 67%

MATCH SCORE TRUST

~~2.1 / 5~~ ↑ 4.3 / 5

SIGN-UP CONVERSION (GOOGLE OAUTH)

3X HIGHER COMPLETION RATE

11 / FUTURE ROADMAP

Scaling trust and validating monetization through iterative testing.

P1 / IMMEDIATE

Usability & Infrastructure

Formal Usability Testing

Conduct 5–8 moderated sessions with real founders to measure task completion and SUS scores.

Production DB Migration

Replace localStorage with Supabase for multi-device access and real-time collaboration.

P2 / NEXT SPRINT

Retention & Engagement

Deadline Notifications

Implement 7-day and 1-day email alerts to directly address the "missed deadline" pain point.

Primary User Interviews

Conduct 5–10 semi-structured interviews to validate if tracking is the primary long-term pain point.

P3 / ROADMAP

Monetization & Scale

Pro Tier A/B Testing

Test landing pages for a £9/month Pro tier (unlimited tracker, alerts) before building infrastructure.

Investor Flow Validation

Interview accelerator directors to validate listing management and analytics workflows.

What Went Well

High-Fidelity Prototyping

Building a production-quality prototype surfaced usability issues (like the "Empty Tracker" state) that low-fidelity tools often miss.

Journey Mapping

Mapping the 5-stage journey transformed vague pain points into specific, testable hypotheses, making design requirements concrete.

What I'd Do Differently

Primary Qualitative Research

The primary gap was the absence of user interviews before design. In production, I would conduct 5-10 semi-structured interviews first.

Service Blueprinting

I would map the "backstage" verification and admin processes alongside the journey map to ensure a seamless end-to-end experience.